

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 649

By Johnson

A RESOLUTION to recognize and honor James Alvin Rogers and his song, "Fly, Eagle, Fly."

WHEREAS, it is the privilege of the members of this General Assembly to recognize those Tennesseans who are wholly devoted to their craft and enrich the lives of their fellow citizens through their art; and

WHEREAS, one such individual is musician and singer-songwriter James Alvin Rogers, whose song, "Fly, Eagle, Fly" was selected as an official State song of the bicentennial with the adoption of Senate Joint Resolution 161 of the 89th General Assembly; and

WHEREAS, a resident of Franklin, Mr. Rogers was born in Chattanooga on December 22, 1949, to Hershel and Elizabeth Rogers; he grew up surrounded by a family that played instruments and sang, and he received his first guitar at the age of eleven; and

WHEREAS, in 1958, he and his family moved across the State line to Fort Oglethorpe, Georgia, where he began playing in groups; his senior year of high school was interrupted with a six-month tour of active duty with the U.S. Army as a member of the Tennessee National Guard, during which time he became famous for his "latrine concerts"; and

WHEREAS, James Rogers graduated from the University of Tennessee at Chattanooga in 1974; though his initial intention was to become a lawyer, his desire to devote his life to music proved a more potent force; and

WHEREAS, in 1975, Mr. Rogers signed with Capitol Records, and from that time until 1983, he traveled throughout the country, performing in large show rooms and in concerts with some of the biggest names in show business, including Alabama, Suzy Bogguss, Roy Clark, Steve Martin, Ricky Skaggs, and Dolly Parton; and

WHEREAS, widely recognized for his talent and musical contributions, Mr. Rogers was the winner of the 1983 National Mountain Music Festival and has been inducted into the Chattanooga Musicians Hall of Fame and the North American Country Music Association International Hall of Fame; and

WHEREAS, for three decades, he was a star performer at Dollywood and at Music Mansion Theater in Pigeon Forge, being honored in the categories of Best Entertainer, Best Show, and Best Theater on several occasions by various outlets and organizations; and

WHEREAS, in addition to "Fly, Eagle, Fly," other compositions of his have been recognized, as well, including "I Guard America," which was adopted by the Enlisted Association of the National Guard of the United States as its official theme song in 1997; two years later, the song was the official theme song of the National Guard at the Senior Leadership Conference in Washington, D.C.; and

WHEREAS, much of his songwriting prowess has been channeled into raising awareness of our country's living symbol of freedom, the bald eagle; "Where Eagles Fly" was the theme song for the Fraternal Order of Eagles International, and "Save the Eagle" was recorded by a slate of country music greats—Lee Greenwood, Ricky Skaggs, Tanya Tucker, Deanna Carter, Terry Clark, Debbie Allen, Joy White, Ricky Lynn Gregg, the Oak Ridge Boys, and James Rogers himself—for the American Eagle Foundation to help aid in the protection and conservation of the bald eagle; and

WHEREAS, throughout his many accomplishments, Mr. Rogers has enjoyed the love and support of his wife, Debbie, and their children, Heather and Justin; and

WHEREAS, it is fitting that we pause to honor the accomplished musician and songwriter James Rogers, whose inspirational words and music have made a lasting impact on the Volunteer State; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we hereby honor James Alvin Rogers for his more than half a century as a performing singer-songwriter and recognize his song, "Fly, Eagle, Fly," and its place in Tennessee history.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.